Jitendra Singh's connivance had pushed the organisation to the brink of disaster.

Borah's exit, with the assembly polls around the corner, is only the latest in a rolling wave of resignations and defections that has hollowed out the Congress's base in Assam. Three sitting MLAs have already moved out, two to the Raijor Dal and one to the Asom Gana Parishad, while another three are preparing to cross over to the BJP.

LEADERSHIP CRISIS

To his credit, Gogoi, the party's Lok Sabha MP from Jorhat, has emerged as the party's most credible challenger to Sarma: young, nationally visible and carrying the advantage of a formidable political legacy. But under his watch, the Congress has been below par at best. The party's panchayat poll performance was a washout and critics say his indecision at critical moments has allowed controversies to fester.

Takeaways

- **Borah's defection exposes Congress's deepening leadership crisis before state polls**
- **Factional rivalries and alleged shadow leadership weaken party**
- **BJP gains narrative advantage, tars Congress with 'Bangladeshi Muslim' taint**

A typical case involved newly inducted leader Rejaul Karim Sarkar, whose provocative remarks the day he joined caused an uproar. Gogoi stayed silent, but just 60 hours later Sarkar quit the party, accusing leader of the Opposition in the assembly, Debabrat Saikia, and party MP Pradyut Bordoloi of being BJP stooges—an allegation reinforced by CM Sarma's assertion that the two would join the BJP at a later date.

After Borah put in his papers, Gogoi had publicly apologised, calling him an asset and acknowledging that wrongs may have been done but it was too late.

The bigger charge against Gogoi is that he has little control over the party. Borah alleges that Rakibul Hussain runs the Assam Congress from the shadows, reducing it to what he derisively calls "Congress (R), R standing for Rakibul". A five-term MLA and ex-minister, Hussain reinforced his clout with a landslide win from Dhubri in 2024, defeating the All India United Democratic Front (AIUDF) chief Badruddin Ajmal by over a million votes. Ironically, Borah says he was "punished" for breaking the alliance with the AIUDF to blunt the BJP's polarising narrative, even though Hussain had been its main architect.

Discontent with Hussain extends beyond Borah. MLAs Abdur Rashid Mandal and Sherman Ali, who have moved to the Raijor Dal, cited him while quitting the party. Early progress in 2026 seat-sharing talks under Borah collapsed after Hussain was brought in, triggering confusion within the Congress and among allies, with Raijor Dal chief Akhil Gogoi publicly voicing his unease.

ADVANTAGE BJP

What sharpens the damage is the political shorthand Sarma has built around Hussain's growing prominence. By branding the Assam Congress "Congress (BM)"—BM for 'Bangladeshi Muslim'—he folds it into his campaign against alleged illegal immigrants, locally called 'Miya'. Borah's resignation letter hands him fresh ammunition. This framing also erases inconvenient facts: Rakibul is an Assamese-speaking Muslim, the son of a former minister, and a once close ally of Sarma when the latter was in the Congress.

The direct electoral impact of Borah's defection may be modest, but it does carry symbolic value. He last won an Assembly seat in 2011 but has intimate knowledge of the party's strategy, alliances and faultlines. More damagingly, his public charge that Hussain runs the Congress feeds directly into the BJP's polarisation playbook. ■

▶ MADHYA PRADESH

Urea at Your Doorstep

Farmers can now order a fixed amount of fertiliser online rather than wait in long queues

By **Rahul Noronha**

THE MADHYA PRADESH GOVERNMENT HAS taken the next step toward solving a problem it claims does not exist. Back in December, agriculture minister Aidal Singh Kansana had at a press conference denied that there was any shortage of fertiliser in the state, never mind the year-long fighting and looting over the issue, or the recent deaths of two farmers waiting outside fertiliser dispensaries. "Show me even one farmer..." he had thundered. But while the minister may have denied any crisis in public, his department was busy rolling out pilots of an initiative called e-VIKAS (e-Vitaran Evam Krishi Urvarak Apoorti Samadhan) in three districts—Jabalpur, Vidisha and Shajapur—all of last year. An online facility, it allows farmers to log in using their Aadhar number and buy a predetermined amount of fertiliser through a QR code. What is more, they now also have the option to have their purchase delivered at home from a nearby private or